CYBER SAFETY GUY

YOUTUBE SHORTS:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

YouTube Shorts are short, vertical videos up to 60 seconds long. They're fast, fun and easy to watch – but it's important to understand how they work and how to keep your child safe.

Here's what parents need to know.

70% of 13–17 year olds watch YouTube Shorts — Ofcom (2023)

40+ BILLION daily views of YouTube Shorts — YouTube (2023)

60 SECONDS max length per Short — YouTube Help

ON MOBILE Most Shorts are watched on phones — Think with Google

1 WHAT THEY ARE

Short, vertical videos up to 60 seconds. Made to watch quickly on mobile.

2 HOW THEY WORK

You swipe up to watch more. The feed is personalised for each user.

3 WHAT KIDS LIKE

Quick, entertaining videos on comedy, gaming, music, sports, animals, DIY and more.

4 KEY FEATURES

Like, Dislike, Share, Comments, Save and Remix (use content in your own Short).

5 THE RISKS

Addictive design, inappropriate content, scams, pressure and privacy risks.

6 THE CONVERSATION

Talk early. Listen often. Set clear boundaries together.

WHAT MAKES SHORTS APPEALING?

- Quick & easy to watch
- Endless variety
- Discover new creators
- Trendy & up-to-date
- Gaming highlights
- Music & dance
- Funny moments
- Creativity & inspiration

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **The algorithm is powerful.** It learns what they watch and shows more of the same.
2. **Not everything is suitable.** Some content can be upsetting, misleading or inappropriate.
3. **It can be addictive.** Short, fast videos can lead to hours of unintentional scrolling.

BY THE NUMBERS

63% of kids aged 8–12 watch YouTube regularly — Ofcom (2023)

47 MINUTES average daily time teenagers spend on YouTube — Ofcom (2023)

1 IN 3 teens say they've seen content on YouTube that they didn't want to see — Pew Research (2022)

70% of teens say YouTube helps them learn new things — Pew Research (2022)

SAFETY FEATURES & SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS

- **Restricted Mode** Filters out potentially mature content.
- **Comments** You control if comments are on or off.
- **Screen Time Reminders** Set reminders to take breaks.
- **Digital Wellbeing** See time watched and manage usage.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Turn on Restricted Mode.
- Set daily time limits.
- Turn off comments if needed.
- Review watch & search history.
- Use a Google Account managed by you.

Find these in: Settings > General

STEP-BY-STEP: KEEP YOUR CHILD SAFE

1. **Explore together.** Watch a few Shorts with your child. Get to know what they like.
2. **Set boundaries.** Agree on time limits and when they can watch.
3. **Check settings.** Turn on Restricted Mode and review privacy settings.
4. **Talk about content.** Discuss what's okay, what's not and how to get help.
5. **Encourage balance.** Support offline activities, sleep and school.
6. **Stay involved.** Keep talking and check in regularly.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

- **Inappropriate Content** Some Shorts may show violence, adult themes or strong language.
- **Misinformation & Dangerous Trends** False or harmful information can spread quickly.
- **Addiction & Screen Time** Endless scrolling can affect sleep, mood and focus.
- **Scams & Clickbait** Tricky links, fake giveaways and "get rich quick" schemes.
- **Privacy Risks** Sharing personal info in comments or videos can be risky.
- **Pressure to Perform** Comparing lives or seeking likes can hurt self-esteem.

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION

- What kind of Shorts do you enjoy watching?
- Have you ever seen something that upset or confused you?
- Do you know how to block or report?
- What would you do if someone asked for your personal info?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE

Open conversations build trust and keep kids safe.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Stay calm. Listen to your child.
- Take screenshots or save the link.
- Note dates, times and usernames.
- Do not delete evidence.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Report the video or channel on YouTube.
- Use the in-app report tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? **CHILDLINE** | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.